Aran: Design References (real, hand-made sites)

For: the new Aran UI design. Use this with the UI Design Spec.

These are sites built and refined by real design teams over years, not one-shot AI templates. Each one lists what to study in it and which Aran page it helps with. Open them, take screenshots of the parts you like, and paste the screenshots into Claude Design as references (with the colour placeholders from the spec, not their colours).

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1. How to spot “AI slop” and avoid it

A generated-looking site usually has most of these. Aran should have none of them.

Slop sign	Do this instead
Purple-to-blue gradient hero, glowing blobs, glassy cards everywhere	One quiet background, flat cards, colour only where it carries meaning (real data, token, leak)
Vague headline (“Revolutionising data security with AI”)	A concrete claim with a number (“Real numbers pass the checksum. Aran’s tokens never do.”)
Three identical feature cards with emoji icons	Show the real thing working: a live log line before and after
Fake dashboard numbers (“99.9% secure”)	Only live server values (every binding in the spec)
Stock 3D shields, padlocks, hooded hackers	Your own diagrams drawn from real data (pipeline, trace map, radar)
Every section the same height, centred text, same spacing	A clear hierarchy: one big idea per screen, dense tables where people work
Animations that move for no reason	Animation that explains a step (a token being built, a key shattering)
Generic sans font at one weight	A deliberate pair: a display face, a readable body face and a strong monospace for digits

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2. Product dashboards (for Overview, Live traffic, Immune layer)

Site	Link	What to study	Aran page
Linear	https://linear.app	Calm dark UI, tight spacing, keyboard-first, subtle motion, crisp sidebar	Shell, all console pages
Vercel	https://vercel.com	Black-and-white restraint, monospace for technical values, deployment logs	Live traffic, Results & tests (job output)

Site	Link	What to study	Aran page
Sentry	https://sentry.io	Error and alert lists with context, stack-trace style detail panels	Immune layer alerts, Live traffic detail
PostHog	https://posthog.com	Playful but honest product site; dense analytics screens	Overview, Results
Grafana	https://grafana.com	Time-series panels, stat tiles, thresholds on charts	Overview stat rows, Immune radar
Tailscale	https://tailscale.com	Explaining a network product with simple diagrams; plain words	Guided tour chapter 1 (pipeline)
Supabase	https://supabase.com	Developer dark theme, code blocks, table editor	Customers table, API docs feel
Raycast	https://raycast.com	Polished dark product shots, compact lists, command palette	Shell, lists
Resend	https://resend.com	Very minimal dark marketing site; strong type	Tour headlines

3. Security and data sites (for the tone of Aran)

Site	Link	What to study	Aran page
Cloudflare Radar	https://radar.cloudflare.com	Real internet-security data shown live, maps, clear charts, honest captions	Overview, Immune layer, Leak trace
1Password	https://1password.com	Trust and security explained without fear-mongering	Tour chapters 2 and 9
Signal	https://signal.org	Privacy product with almost no decoration	Tone of all copy
GitHub Security	https://github.com/security	Security features shown as real UI, not illustrations	How it works
Oxide Computer	https://oxide.computer	Engineering-led site, technical diagrams, monospace done well	How it works, Under the hood
TigerBeetle	https://tigerbeetle.com	Financial database explained with hard numbers and bold type	Evidence chapter, Results

4. Finance and Indian fintech (for the banking feel)

Site	Link	What to study	Aran page
Stripe	https://stripe.com	Gold standard for explaining payments; precise diagrams; docs	Tour, How it works
Stripe Docs	https://docs.stripe.com	Two-column docs with live code and request/response panels	Live traffic (before/after), API reference
Mercury	https://mercury.com	Banking UI that feels calm and premium; tables of transactions	Customers & erasure
Ramp	https://ramp.com	Finance dashboards, clear numbers, strong hierarchy	Overview
Wise	https://wise.com	Plain-language money explanations, friendly but exact	Tour copy
Razorpay	https://razorpay.com	Indian payments product, UPI flows, Indian number formatting	Live traffic samples, Overview
Zerodha Kite	https://kite.zerodha.com	Extremely fast, minimal Indian trading UI; dense data done cleanly	Tables, stat tiles
Setu	https://setu.co	Indian banking APIs (account aggregator, UPI) presented for developers	API reference feel

5. Animated and interactive explainers (for the guided tour)

Site	Link	What to study	Aran chapter
Bartosz Ciechanowski	https://ciechanow.ski	The best step-by-step interactive explainers on the web; every slider changes a real model	Check digits, Building a token
Red Blob Games	https://www.redblobgames.com	Algorithms explained with small interactive diagrams you can drag	Check digits, Disguises
Nicky Case	https://ncase.me	Playable explanations, friendly tone, one idea at a time	Immune system, Erasure
Distill	https://distill.pub	Machine-learning ideas explained with interactive figures	Finding data (detector clues)
The Pudding	https://pudding.cool	Data stories with scroll-driven animation	Problem, Evidence

Site	Link	What to study	Aran chapter
Our World in Data	https://ourworldindata.org	Clear, honest charts with sources under every one	Evidence, Results

6. Galleries curated by people (to find more)

Gallery	Link	Use it for
Minimal Gallery	https://minimal.gallery	Hand-picked minimal sites
SiteInspire	https://www.siteinspire.com	Large curated showcase, filter by style and type
Godly	https://godly.website	Bold, high-craft sites with motion previews
Land-book	https://land-book.com	Landing pages by category
Mobbin	https://mobbin.com	Real screens from shipped apps, searchable by pattern (tables, empty states, alerts)
Refero	https://refero.design	Real web app screens by pattern; good for dashboards and states
Dark Mode Design	https://www.darkmodedesign.com	Dark themes only, since Aran defaults to dark

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7. What to take from each, page by page

Aran page	Look at first	Steal this idea
Shell (sidebar, top bar)	Linear, Raycast	Narrow sidebar, quiet active state, one strip of status text
Guided tour	Ciechanowski, Red Blob Games, Stripe	One idea per screen, step controls, diagram first and text second
Overview	Cloudflare Radar, Grafana, Ramp	Big live numbers with a small note each; one chart per idea
Live traffic	Stripe Docs, Vercel logs	Request on the left, result on the right, monospace everything
Customers & erasure	Mercury, Zerodha Kite	Dense, readable table; one clear destructive action with a confirm
Leak trace	Cloudflare Radar, Sentry	A verdict line first, evidence table second
Immune layer	Grafana, Sentry	Mode badge, threshold bands, alert list with “resolve” actions
Results & tests	Our World in Data, Vercel	Source and date under every table; live job output
How it works	Oxide, TigerBeetle	Technical diagrams and hard numbers, no stock art

8. How to use these in Claude Design

1. Pick 3 to 5 references, not 30. Too many makes a blend that looks like nothing.
2. Screenshot only the part you want (a table, a stat row, a step control), not the whole page.
3. In Claude Design, paste the screenshot and say what you want from it, for example: “Use the table density and row hover from this screenshot. Use our tokens, not its colours.”
4. Keep the three meaning colours (`{real-data-color}`, `{token-color}`, `{leak-color}`) for meaning only.
5. Check each screen against the slop list in section 1 before you move on.

All links were chosen as long-running, human-designed sites at the time of writing (October 2026). If one has changed, use the galleries in section 6 to find a replacement.